We play too much international cricket. Gambles are being taken that can shorten careers. I was rested for the one-day series against the Australians following the Ashes win. In hindsight, the same consideration should have been shown towards a struggling Jonathan Trott. He was bounced out first ball a couple of times, which deepened his problems. KP, too, should have been given room to breathe.

My final words to the group at the end of that Oval Test were intended to act as a punctuation mark between summer and winter. 'I want everyone to be as fit as a butcher's dog for the tour,' I told them. 'That's the only thing we can control between now and Australia.' Those words had greater relevance, and consequence, than I realized at the time.

Swanny was in pain but got a little greedy. He loves Australia, and gave his son Wilfred the middle name Sydney, so saying farewell at the SCG as part of another winning England team was tempting. His elbow injury was severe and had required two operations. One, in America, was conducted by a specialist in baseball injuries. Swanny spent fifty minutes of every hour in an electrically charged sling for two days and nights after surgery.

If that was storing up trouble, our decision to stage another pre-tour hardship camp was a big mistake. The boys looked back at the one we'd staged in Germany with fear, amusement and a strange sense of satisfaction. To this day, Ravi Bopara talks about it. He loved every press-up, each carefully planned humiliation.

If that one was Teutonic, this one, held in Stafford, was shambolic. Other than knowing it was designed to be less physical, in order to reveal different aspects of character and alternative styles of leadership, Andy Flower went into it as blindly as the rest of us. It transpired that we would be trained in surveillance techniques in an operation that would climax with a firefight.

The prospect brought out the little boy in us all. Who wouldn't want to learn how to install tracking devices on a car, and to tail it in traffic? How devious would we be when ordered to act as a spy, following someone into a pub and reporting back overheard snippets of conversation? It all seemed harmless fun.

It was terrible. All hotels in the area were fully booked, so we had to travel for more than half an hour to the rendezvous point for the daily mission. The food was awful. We were briefed for hours, sitting uncomfortably in parked cars, before undertaking a farcical set of exercises. On one occasion, when we were tasked to secretly film a stash of plastic